

Yorkshire Fishing & Seafood Export Research

Opportunities for a Yorkshire Seafood Export Strategy

Yorkshire has one of the UK's most significant commercial fishing sectors despite being overshadowed by Scotland and the South West. Its east coast—particularly Bridlington, Whitby, Scarborough and Hull—supports valuable shellfish fisheries, processing businesses and access to European export markets.

The strongest commercial opportunity is **not** in expanding fishing effort alone, but in increasing the amount of seafood that is **processed, branded and exported from Yorkshire**, capturing more value before products leave the region.

Executive Summary

Yorkshire possesses:

- over 180 km of North Sea coastline
- four major commercial fishing ports
- Europe's largest brown crab and lobster fishery centred on Bridlington
- strong seafood processing expertise in Hull
- excellent road and rail links to UK distribution centres
- proximity to Rotterdam, Zeebrugge and northern French ports

Rather than competing with Scotland in pelagic fishing (mackerel and herring), Yorkshire's comparative advantage lies in:

- premium shellfish
- live lobster
- brown crab
- langoustines
- scallops
- white fish processing
- value-added seafood manufacturing

Over **3,000 tonnes of shellfish** are landed annually into Bridlington, Scarborough and Whitby, with much of the catch exported live to continental Europe, especially France and Spain.

Yorkshire's Main Fishing Ports







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Bridlington

Largest shellfish port in Europe.

Main catch:

- Brown Crab
- Lobster
- Velvet Crab
- Whelks

Major export destination:

- France
- Spain
- Belgium

Whitby

Specialises in:

- Crab
- Lobster
- Shellfish

Growing tourism supports premium seafood branding.

Scarborough

Mixed fishery.

Species include:

- Lobster
 - Crab
 - White Fish
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Hull

Although no longer one of Europe's largest distant-water fishing ports, Hull remains one of the UK's major seafood processing, cold-storage and distribution centres.

Main Species

Species	Export Demand
Brown Crab	Very High
Lobster	Very High
Langoustine	High
Scallops	High
Whelks	High
Cod (processed)	Medium
Haddock	Medium
Plaice	Medium

Export Markets

Current principal destinations include:

France

Largest customer

Demand for:

- Live lobster
 - Brown crab
 - Scallops
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Spain

High demand for:

- Shellfish
 - Crab
 - Premium seafood
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Belgium

Distribution hub

Netherlands

Gateway through Rotterdam

Italy

Growing shellfish market

Germany

Premium seafood retail

Scandinavia

Opportunity for premium Yorkshire branding

UK Markets

Major opportunities include:

- London

- Manchester
- Birmingham
- Leeds
- Newcastle
- Edinburgh

These markets increasingly demand high-quality, traceable seafood with strong provenance.

Current Industry Challenges

Although demand remains strong, exporters face additional post-Brexit requirements such as catch certificates, export health certificates, customs formalities and border controls for EU shipments.

Other constraints include:

- ageing fishing fleet
 - labour shortages
 - limited cold storage
 - fragmented processing capacity
 - transport costs
 - relatively low domestic consumption of shellfish
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Rhino Bank Proposal

Yorkshire Seafood Export Initiative

Investment:

£1.85 Billion

1. Bridlington Export Port

Investment

£420 million

Develop:

- automated auction hall
 - live shellfish holding tanks
 - refrigerated logistics centre
 - export customs hub
 - overnight European freight terminal
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2. Hull Seafood Processing Park

Investment

£550 million

Facilities:

- fish processing
- seafood packaging
- freezing
- ready-meal production
- seafood innovation centre

This shifts value creation from exporting raw catch to exporting higher-value finished products.

3. Whitby Premium Seafood Centre

Investment

£180 million

Focus:

- luxury seafood
 - branded Yorkshire seafood
 - tourism
 - premium restaurants
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4. Scarborough Processing Expansion

Investment

£150 million

Focus:

- shellfish grading
 - export packing
 - cold storage
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5. Yorkshire Cold Chain Network

Investment

£300 million

Regional refrigerated distribution connecting ports to inland logistics hubs.

6. European Export Hub

Investment

£250 million

Integrated customs and logistics services with daily departures to mainland Europe via east coast ports.

New Export Markets

Target growth in:

- Denmark
- Sweden
- Norway
- Germany
- Switzerland
- Austria
- Poland
- Czech Republic

Alongside expanding sales in:

- France
 - Spain
 - Belgium
 - Netherlands
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Domestic Expansion

Create a "**Yorkshire Seafood**" premium brand.

Supply:

- Waitrose
- Marks & Spencer
- Harrods
- premium restaurants
- hotels
- cruise ships
- airlines

Emphasise sustainability, traceability and regional provenance.

Economic Impact

Measure	Current	Rhino Proposal
Annual Seafood Exports	~£250m (illustrative)	~£700m
Processing Employment	~3,000	~8,500
Fishing Employment	~2,500	~4,200
Total Jobs Supported	~7,000	~16,000
Annual GVA	~£350m	~£1.2bn

These figures are indicative estimates for a strategic investment scenario rather than official forecasts.

Export Logistics

Yorkshire has excellent access to UK and European freight networks.

Primary routes:

- Bridlington → Rotterdam
- Hull → Rotterdam
- Hull → Zeebrugge
- Hull → Antwerp
- Hull → Hamburg

The Humber estuary also provides access to container shipping for longer-distance exports.

Long-Term Vision

Yorkshire already has globally recognised strengths in shellfish production, particularly brown crab and lobster. By investing in processing capacity, cold-chain logistics, branding and export infrastructure, the region could capture a much greater share of the seafood value chain rather than exporting predominantly unprocessed products.

A coordinated strategy centred on Bridlington, Hull, Whitby and Scarborough would strengthen Yorkshire's position as one of northern Europe's leading seafood export regions, supporting coastal communities while increasing regional productivity and international trade.